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(JTA) - Bush denies seeking Arafat ouster

President Bush denied a report that he wants to sideline Palestinian Authority President Yasser Arafat. Speaking to reporters Thursday, Bush reiterated that he has been disappointed with Arafat, but again called on Arafat to crack down on terrorism. On Wednesday, the Israeli daily Ha'aretz cited an Israeli source as saying the White House wants to turn Arafat into a figurehead and have someone else take on the day-to-day duties of the Palestinian leadership.

(JTA) - Deal on Bethlehem standoff

A deal has been reached to end the standoff at Bethlehem's Church of the Nativity, an Israeli official said. Under the deal, several countries would take some of the 13 Palestinians accused by Israel of carrying out terrorist actions, the official told The Associated Press on Thursday.

(JTA) - Jewish group downsizes

The United Jewish Communities is laying off staff and closing regional offices to "redesign" and optimize the federation system, officials told JTA. The umbrella group for North American federations will cut 38 percent of its field operations by laying off 16 employees in its regional offices, closing its Chicago and South Florida offices and housing its New Jersey office in its Manhattan headquarters, the officials added. The move is part of an overall plan to cut UJC's budget this year from $50.3 million to $42.5 million, brought on by lean economic times and the UJC's ongoing effort to convert its field staff to teams of consultants.

(JTA) - Israeli forces mass near Gaza

The Israeli army massed forces Thursday near the Gaza Strip. The move came as Israel's Security Cabinet approved action against "terrorist targets" in retaliation for a deadly Palestinian suicide bombing Tuesday night in Rishon le-Zion. Cabinet members did not say what type of response they authorized, but a strike against Gaza was widely expected following reports that the terrorist who carried out the bombing, which killed 15 Israelis and wounded 60, came from Gaza. The ministers did not discuss the possibility of expelling Palestinian Authority President Yasser Arafat, Israel Radio reported. Prime Minister Ariel Sharon convened the Security Cabinet at an air force base early Thursday morning following his return from the United States. Israeli security officials cautioned Thursday that a military offensive similar to the recent anti- terror campaign in the West Bank would be far more difficult to carry out in Gaza. Meanwhile, military officials confirmed that they are calling up reservists, but would not say how many.

(JTA) - Nativity church deal stalled

A deal to end the standoff at Bethlehem's Church of the Nativity broke down Thursday, just hours after a partial solution seemed in place. Earlier Thursday, Israeli and Palestinian negotiators said a deal had been achieved to allow dozens of Palestinians to emerge from the church, leaving behind 13 suspected militants whom Israel wants deported. Buses pulled into Manger Square to transport those inside the church to their destinations. But when the talks collapsed, the buses drove away empty. An Israeli negotiator told The Associated Press that the Palestinians caused the delay when they made a last-minute demand that a European envoy enter the church to remain with

the 13 until a host country is found. The Palestinian side said Israel refused to implement the deal.

(JTA) - P.A.: 16 Hamas members arrested

Palestinian police said they arrested 16 Hamas members in the Gaza Strip. Thursday's arrests came after the United States called on Palestinian Authority President Yasser Arafat to crack down on Palestinian terrorists. In the past, Palestinian police temporarily detained Hamas leaders, but released them soon after. In some cases, it appeared the Palestinians took the moves largely to protect Hamas members from possible Israeli attack. White House spokesman Ari Fleischer said Thursday that the United States hoped those arrested remained jailed as a proof of "good government."

(JTA) - Annan to probe Jenin operation

U.N. Secretary-General Kofi Annan plans to compile a report on Israel's military operation last month in the Jenin refugee camp. The move comes following a request earlier this week by the U.N. General Assembly, Annan's spokesman said Wednesday. Annan will seek Israel cooperation in preparing the report, he added. Annan canceled a U.N. fact-finding mission that was to visit the camp after the United Nations and Israel could not come to terms on the team's makeup and mandate.

(JTA) - Israelis to meet Annan

Several Israeli officials and two children will meet Kofi Annan on Thursday to discuss the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and Arab attempts to politicize a current U.N. session on children. The delegation will be headed by Israeli Justice Minister Meir Sheetrit and U.N. Ambassador Yehuda Lancry.

(JTA) - Arafat statement a 'positive sign'

President Bush said he believes Yasser Arafat's comments rejecting terrorism were an "incredibly positive sign." Meeting Wednesday with Jordan's King Abdullah at the White House, Bush said he hopes the Palestinian Authority president's actions would match the words he delivered in an address in Arabic to his people earlier that day. Bush also said he believes Israeli Prime Minister Ariel Sharon has the right to respond to Arab terror attacks, but added, "My hope is that the prime minister keeps his vision for peace alive."

(JTA) - Posters call for attacks on Arabs

An extremist Jewish group claimed responsibility for launching anti- Arab attacks during the past 18 months. Posters signed by a group calling itself the Jewish Underground have appeared recently in West Bank settlements, Army Radio reported. The posters contain an admission by the group that it killed eight Arabs during the intifada and planted pipe bombs last March in the yard of an Arab school in eastern Jerusalem. The posters also called on the public to join in the underground operations against Palestinians and Arab citizens of Israel, saying "their time has come." The Yesha Council, which represents settlers in the West Bank and Gaza Strip, condemned the posters and asked police to investigate.

(JTA) - Israeli post in Gaza attacked

A mortar shell was fired Thursday at an Israeli army position in the Gaza Strip. There were no reports of injuries. On Wednesday night, Israeli troops launched anti-terror missions in the West Bank. About 10 Palestinians were arrested in operations around Tulkarm.

(JTA) - 900,000 rallied for Israel

About 900,000 people participated in pro-Israel rallies last month. The rallies were held in 94 cities around the world as Israeli forces conducted a massive anti-terror operation in the West Bank, according to the chairman of the Jewish Agency for Israel, Sallai Meridor. In addition, Meridor said this week, hundreds of Jewish leaders from around

the world came to Israel recently on solidarity missions.

(JTA) - French leader: Don't boycott

Now is not the time for a boycott of French products, a French Jewish leader said. Roger Cukierman made the comment Wednesday during a briefing in New York sponsored by the Conference of Presidents of Major American Jewish Organizations. Some U.S. Jews have called for a boycott, charging the French government is not doing enough to combat a recent spate of anti-Semitic incidents in France. "We believe this attitude would be counterproductive,' said Cukierman, president of CRIF, the umbrella group of secular French Jewish organizations. "We do hope that with the election of the new government" in France, "things will be taken much more seriously in the future. We believe, at last, that we will see some improvement."

(JTA) - U.S. high court justice tours Israel

A trip to Israel heightened a U.S. Supreme Court justice's appreciation for the Jewish state. Addressing the American Jewish Committee's annual meeting Wednesday, Stephen Breyer said he was struck by the beauty and diversity of the country, but noted a "sadness" there. He also said he noticed that Israelis were nervous and worried about their children. Breyer, who visited Israel as a guest of Israeli Supreme Court President Aharon Barak, also told the AJCommittee gathering that the United States faces security problems similar to Israel's.

(JTA) - London sheik to go on trial

About 100 people demonstrated in London to show their support for a radical Muslim cleric accused of urging his followers to kill Jews and Hindus. Thursday's demonstration took place as Sheik Abdullah Faisal, 38, made a brief appearance at London's Old Bailey court. A trial date will be set on June 7.

(JTA) - Jewish leader blasts Swiss government

The leader of Swiss Jewry attacked his government for its "one-sided statements" favoring the Palestinians. "In various statements, the Swiss government has criticized Israel's war on terrorism," Alfred Donath said Thursday at the annual meeting of the Federation of Jewish Communities in Switzerland. "This attitude only serves to support the already high levels of anti- Semitism" in Switzerland, he added. He also called on Swiss Jews to fight anti-Semitism and continue showing solidarity with Israel.

(JTA) - Jew wins Berkeley campus election

A pro-Israel Jew was elected student body president at the University of California's Berkeley campus. Sophomore Jesse Gabriel's victory came amid growing anti-Semitic sentiment on campus. Gabriel said he could not have achieved his tight 150-vote lead "without a lot of help" from Jews on campus. The results come as great news to many Jewish students, who have felt targeted by anti-Semitic hostility linked to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

(JTA) - Study points to pre-school challenges

Jewish early childhood programs enroll twice as many children as 10 years ago, according to a new study. Just the same, the study says, such programs only reach 14 percent of American Jewish youngsters. The survey by the Jewish Early Childhood Education Partnership, a national advocacy group, offers a range of new data about Jewish pre-elementary programs. Among the highlights: Sixty-nine percent of early childhood professionals in Jewish programs are Jewish, with the percentage of non-Jewish teachers tripling since 1994; Jewish teachers in the programs have generally low levels of Jewish education, with 45 percent having no Jewish education beyond Hebrew school; and the average salary for teachers is $19,400, with no benefits.

(JTA) - Czech bill sets new deadline for art claims

The Czech Senate passed a bill extending the deadline for claiming Nazi-looted art to the end of 2006. The bill

passed Thursday has yet to be signed into law by President Vaclav Havel. Under the current law, the deadline is the end of this year. The new bill was drafted following an initiative by Czech Jewish leaders, who argued that many people need more time to lay claim to thousands of looted works listed by the Czech Ministry of Culture.

(JTA) - Site eyes anti-Zionism

Yad Vashem's Web site is addressing the role of anti-Semitism and the Holocaust in the current Israeli-Palestinian conflict. A section of the Jerusalem- based Holocaust museum's site addresses issues including the relationship of anti-Semitism and anti-Zionism, and comparisons between the current conflict and the Holocaust. The site can be accessed at www.yadvashem.org.

(JTA) - Fast-food restaurants bombed

A bomb exploded Thursday outside two U.S.-based fast-food restaurants in Lebanon. Police said 3 pounds of TNT were used in the blast outside the Kentucky Fried Chicken and Hardees restaurants in the port city of Tripoli. Police said they were investigating whether the blast was linked to anger over Washington's perceived support for Israel.

(JTA) - Children march for Palestinians

About 200 children marched in Cape Town calling to protect the rights of Palestinian children. Organizers of Wednesday's march asked South African President Thabo Mbeki to cut all diplomatic and trade ties with Israel. Meanwhile, the South African government condemned Tuesday's suicide bombing in Rishon le-Zion, but said peace will prevail in the region only when Israel stops its alleged aggression against Palestinians.

(JTA) - House may seek more funds for Israel

[Republican leaders in the U.S. House of Representatives are considering adding $200 million in aid to Israel.] Congressional sources say the additional money, which has not been earmarked by the White House as part of its annual supplemental aid package, is expected to be debated Thursday by the House Appropriations Committee and could go before the full House next week. Lawmakers passed a resolution last week expressing solidarity with Israel and seeking additional funds for the Jewish state.

(JTA) - Powell: U.S. peacemaking to persist

[The United States will continue pressing for a Middle East peace accord despite the latest suicide bombing, Colin Powell said.] "Every time one of these events happens, it takes us off a course we were on for a while," the U.S. secretary of state said Wednesday after meeting with British Foreign Secretary Jack Straw. But "at the end of the day, we have to find a political solution."

(JTA) - Suspect in terror case freed

[An Argentine court freed a former police officer accused of playing a role in the 1994 bombing of the Jewish community center in Buenos Aires.] Alberto Huici, a former police superintendent, was one of 20 people being tried in connection with the bombing, which killed 85 people and injured hundreds. Huici was freed Tuesday after spending six years in prison. He was not directly implicated in the bombing, and court officials said he already had served enough time for allegedly extorting others accused of carrying out the attack. In another development, Argentine President Eduardo Duhalde said this week the attack on the AMIA community center has a direct connection to the Sept. 11 attacks in the United States. When court officials pressed Duhalde, he said he based his statement on an article he had read in Jane's Defense Weekly.

(JTA) - Russian paper blasts Israel

[An article in a popular pro-Communist newspaper questioned Israel's right to exist.] The article in Sovietskaya Rossiya also said "the armed settlers on Palestinian lands are straightforward occupiers, and the blows struck

against them by Palestinian suicide bombers are a legitimate punishment." The article also called Israel "a vast U.S. military base in the Near East that Washington uses to control the region's oil reserves."

(JTA) - Americans seek even-handed response

[Two-thirds of Americans polled believe the United States should be even-handed in its Middle East policies, according to a new survey.] The poll, conducted by the Program on International Policy Attitudes at the University of Maryland, found that only 22 percent of Americans believe the United States should take Israel's side, although 58 percent believe the Bush administration's policies favor Israel. The poll, which has a 3.5 percent margin of error, also found that 70 percent of people support President Bush's involvement in the Middle East and that more than half of the respondents believe an international group, such as the United Nations, should lead the effort to resolve the conflict.

(JTA) - Anti-Israel efforts at U.N. session on children

[Anti-Israel resolutions are afoot at the U.N.'s special session on children this week.] One resolution condemning Israel for its treatment of Palestinian children is planned for a vote Friday. If adopted, the resolution would be the session's only reference to any particular conflict. JTA END

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